Today is the 32 Sunday in Ordinary Time: We are coming to the end of the liturgical year, the 29 November marks the beginning of Advent. The readings at Mass for the next few weeks will concentrate on the end of time and on the theme of watchfulness. The Gospel today (Matthew 25:1-13) speaks of being prepared for the second coming of Jesus. When we recite the Creed at Mass we pray: *"He will come again in glory to judge the living and the dead."* We do not know when Jesus will return again. Matthew 24:36 states *"Of that day and hour (when Jesus will return) no one knows, not even the angels of heaven, but My Father only*" Today we read of the ten bridesmaids waiting for the bridegroom to arrive for the feast. Five were wise and five were foolish. There is a delay in the bridegroom arriving for his feast. None are watching when the bridegroom arrives. All are asleep! They get their lamps ready. The foolish ones have no oil for the lamps and they beg for some of the oil from the wise ones who have only oil for their own lamps. Are the wise bridesmaids being terribly selfish in not sharing some of their oil with them? However we all know that there are just some things in life that are not transferable to others. The oil stands for faith and good works and we just cannot pass them on to others. You can't borrow the oil of faith. You can't borrow another's good works. **You must respond to God's call yourself**. St. Augustine and other ancient writers saw the oil as a symbol of love: a love which we cannot buy but receive as a gift, which we keep in our hearts and practise in good works. When we reawaken for the final judgement, we will be assessed on the basis of the love we have shown during our earthly lives. St. Matthew, in today's Gospel, is calling his community, and is calling us also, to responsible discipleship in the face of the delay in the return of Jesus as Judge. Discipleship is not passive waiting till the end of time – what is needed is oil – which is good deeds. It is about active engagement in the present which will determine the shape of our future. This is a tragic parable because the foolish bridesmaids failed to make adequate preparations to pursue their intentions of sharing in the wedding feast. When they got back to the entrance to the feast they found the door closed to them. All ten bridesmaids were waiting. They all had the same opportunity and same oil lamps. They all could have gathered the oils in on time. They all were preparing and waiting for the same wedding. They all had the same bridegroom coming to them… but only five of them were taking the long-term view and came fully prepared… The final words of today's Gospel – *Be Watchful, Be Prepared, Be Vigilant.* Fr. Charles CP



November Dead Lists: are available in the church and the Parish Office in The Houben Centre. They can be left in the box provided or handed in at The Parish Office. We thank you for your cooperation at this time of the year.

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S.V.D.P: Meeting Wednesday night at 7pm in the Houben Centre.
Holy Cross Choir: 7:30pm Wednesday. In the Houben Centre
AA: Wednesday 7pm – 8:00, Saturday 11 – 1pm Houben Centre
NA: Sunday 7:30 – 8:30pm in the Houben Centre
Prayer Group: 8pm Sunday in the Houben Centre
Legion of Mary: 7pm Thursday in the Houben Centre.
First Friday Film: 8pm in The Houben Centre.
Film in The Houben Centre: Friday 27th November 7:30pm Our Lady of Knock.
Old School Café: 9:30am – 1:30pm. Monday – Friday
We Welcome new volunteers
Weekly Bingo each Tuesday: From 7pm Flax Room
Christmas Craft Fayre: Sunday 6th December 10am – 2pm in Houben Centre.

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The Listening café at the Houben Centre: Do you dabble in poetry, songwriting, or storytelling? Join us for an evening of homegrown, original works in a warm, inviting space. Friday 13h November 7:30 – 9:30pm. (Registration for performers opens at 7pm). Café open for light refreshments. (No alcohol event, Donations voluntary).

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Knock All Night Vigil: Monday 7th December , Departure from Clonard Monastery 1pm returning to Belfast 8th December at noon. Price £75.
This includes Dinner & Breakfast. To book Phone Brendan on 90 665211.
9am – 5pm. Monday – Friday. £20 deposit required.

Talk: The Second World War through Jesuit Archives

Join us in the Belfast Jesuit Centre on Thursday 12th November at 7.00pm, for a fascinating illustrated talk by Damien Burke, Archivist of the Irish Jesuit Province and co-editor of *The Second World War through Jesuit Archives: The Case of Europe (1939–1945)*. Drawing on letters, diaries and archival records from across Europe, this illustrated talk explores the human experience of war through stories of faith, service and resilience. All are welcome. Light refreshments provided. Small donation suggested.

Additional Masses during Lent: **Monday Novena Mass as usual 7pm, Wednesday 7pm.**
Confessions: **15 Minutes before each mass by the celebrant of the mass.**
Music Sunday: **7pm Vigil Tanya and Anne, 10am Mass Betty & James, 12 noon Mass Organist Mark P. Laverty & Holy Cross Choir. 7pm folk Group.**
Readers: **Sr. Kathleen, Wilma Lynch, Arthur Kealey, Michelle McCullagh, Brian Lundy, Chris McMullan, John McParland**
Kate Lynch, Michael Stevenson, Kathleen Osbourne, Rose Kilmartin, Betty Magee.